THE ROYAL BRITISH LEGION, PARIS BRANCH

NEWSLETTER – January 2017

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Chairman's Report

After some 18 years of energetic commitment to The Royal British Legion Paris Branch, Roger Thorn stood down as our Chairman at the Branch's AGM held at the Clubhouse 28 November 2016. I was elected to take over from Roger, having been your Vice-Chairman for a number of years.

I open this newsletter by thanking all those who stood for and were elected to the Committee. I am very pleased to know that I have the continuing support of the Officers on the Standing Committee, Janet Warby and Ian McDonald, as well as that of other members of the Committee. The limitations of space don't allow me the opportunity to name everyone so I have attached a list of their names together with a note of their main area of activity and responsibility. I am truly sad that after many years of loyal service to the Legion, Jim Cockle has decided to stand down. I appreciate his reasons for doing so: he will be sorely missed!

Your Committee perceives the beginning of a new year as an appropriate opportunity not only to continue with the projects and activities that have already been launched, but also to "kick-start" other initiatives that have been discussed. You will recall that in my election address I mentioned the need for us to engage actively in organic growth in both membership and activities. We have to focus on those structures we already have in place, and to evaluate how we can improve, enlarge and enhance them. We are always actively seeking new members and also assessing how we can develop our activities. Your help in these areas would be greatly appreciated!

My priority is to establish effective communication with each of our members, and with prospective members. Mark Yates, together with Caroline Clopet, will be looking at this area, concentrating especially on developing our website and our Facebook page. In this respect we are aware that some people do not have Internet access so you will find attached a list of the winners of the Christmas Tombola draw that took place at our very successful Christmas lunch for which I must thank Tony Bennett, our stalwart chef who can always be relied upon to serve us superb meals! Also included with this newsletter is a list of some of this year's events. Please take the time to add these to your agenda so as to ensure you do not miss out on them.

Our January lunch (attended by 31 members!) was followed by a most interesting, enlightening and enjoyable presentation, by Colonel Geoffrey Cardozo on the Foundation Franco-Britannique de Sillery,

My hope is that we shall be able to tempt you with more "extras" similar to this on future occasions.
Your Committee's intention is to be able to offer members the choice of attending at least two significant events per month, apart from July and August. If you are interested, I would advise your making an early booking.

With this in mind, on 21 February we will be holding a Branch General Meeting in our Clubhouse. This meeting is open to all members, and I hope that many of you will come. This will be an opportunity to hear from the Committee and to learn about what the Paris Branch is doing now. You will also hear about our plans for the future and, of course, you'll be given every opportunity to ask us questions! By mid-February Janet Warby, our Secretary, will be sending you more details of this event. We will also be holding a Farewell Dinner for Roger Thorn on 24 February, the details of which will be sent out before the end of January.
In March, in addition to our monthly lunch, we are planning a Wine Tasting evening that will also include a small supper. Details of which will be sent out to you nearer the time. Our Events Manager, Ed Plunkett, plans all these activities in order to ensure our members have more than just a monthly lunch and the Legion magazine to look forward to!

I also wish that we establish and maintain firmer links with our elderly members who find the Clubhouse too far for them to travel. I am working on how to develop this idea.
Should you have any comments, ideas or suggestions regarding the Royal British Legion, Paris Branch, please feel free to contact me. I would welcome hearing from you.

David Bean

Chairman

TRBL, Paris Branch
Members of the Committee

President: Col. Christopher Borneman

Chairman: David Bean (Welfare)

Officers:
Secretary: Janet Warby
Treasurer: Ian McDonald

Ordinary Members:
Brian (Tony) Bennett (Chef and House Manager)
Jon Cooper
Caroline Clopet (Communications)
Max Genock
Janet Hadley (Schools Project)
Etienne Ignatovitch (Co-Proprietaires)
Richard Neave
Edouard Plunkett (Events)
Mark Yates (Membership & Website)

Ex- Officio Members:
William (Bill) Beauclerk -- RNVRA
Giselle Corrigan -- 40/8 and American Legion
Didier Dumont -- Bennecourt (Twinned with Coldstream, Scotland)
Rev. Canon Alyson Lamb - Chaplain
Noreen Riols -- SOE
Graham Scott -- RAFA

Members with Special Responsibilities:
Parade Marshall: Roger Warby
Poppy Organiser: Bridget Terrell
Standard Bearers: Janet Warby & Fiona Terris

Dates for your Agendas

21 February: RBL Branch General Meeting

23 February: RBL Lunch

24 February: Retirement Dinner for Roger Thorn

16 March: RBL Lunch

8 April: Grand National

20 April: RBL Lunch

23 April: Churchill / De Gaulle Commemoration, Paris

30 April: Ceremony – RAF Monument, Maisons Laffitte

8 May: Jour de la Victoire(Various Ceremonies in Ile de France)
incl. Maisons Laffitte, Marly le Roi, Verneuil sur Seine

9 May: RBL General Meeting

18 May: RBL Lunch

15 June: RBL Lunch

18 June: Ceremony – Verneuil sur Seine

4 August: Rekindling of the Flame
l'Arc de Triomphe

3 September: Pedal to Paris at l'Arc de Triomphe

30 September: Prix de l'Arc de Triomphe Race

11 November: Service of Remembrance, Paris

CHRISTMAS TOMBOLA RESULTS

Prize	Name	Ticket Number	Claimed/Not Claimed
Cherry Stone Cusion	Elizabeth Hallows	OOO838	Not Claimed
Big Book on Vegetables	Said Alwan	OOO485	Not Claimed
Salt & Pepper Set	Alex Sim		Claimed
Mantle Clock	Jean-Jacques Auduc	1945	Not Claimed
Gold Cufflinks	Alex Sim		Claimed
Alarm Clock & Flannels	Carol Morris	OO2476	Not Claimed
Toy Cars	John Crothers		Claimed
Silver Cufflinks	Tony Bennett		Claimed
Ceremic Beer Mug	Jim Cockle		Claimed
Chinese Tea Pot and cups	Diana Neill	OO2531	Not Claimed
Prosseco & Chocs	Graham Scott		Claimed
DFDS Sailing ticket	Warby		Claimed
Brittany Ferries Voucher	Genock		Claimed
Bateaux Mouches tickets	Gillian Templeton B/F	OO2492	Not Claimed
Bottle of Pol Roger	Ann Morley		Claimed
Bottle of Pol Roger	Jim Cockle		Claimed
Reminiscing Game	Tina Border Force	OOO483	Not Claimed
France Galop Tickets	John Crothers		Claimed
France Galop Tickets	Richard Hallows	OOO833	Not Claimed
France Galop Tickets	Tony Bennett		Claimed
France Galop Tickets	Tina Border Force	OO2484	Not Claimed
France Galop Tickets	Carol Morris	OO2478	Not Claimed
Rugby shaped toilet bag	Patrick Gautier Lynham		Claimed
Desk Diary 2017	Bob Heath		Claimed
Desk Diary 2017	Serena Stern		Claimed
Ceremic Beer Mug	C. Fewkes	OOO199	Not Claimed
Soap	Louise Cleach		Claimed
Small Diary 2017	Rita Muller	OO2726	Not Claimed
Small Diary 2017	Ian Thompson	OO1871	Not Claimed

The Chairman, Officers and Committee would like to thank all who took part in the Christmas draw and a very big "Thank You" to all who donated gifts. Please contact Mark Yates (06 86 08 68 19 – mfyates@gmail.com) or Janet Warby (01 39 28 90 28 – janetwarby@yahoo.com) to arrange a time to collect your prize(s).

Dear Members,

Branch General Meeting

In accordance with our Membership Handbook and Royal Charter rules, we will be holding a Branch General Meeting on Tuesday 21st February at 18h00 at the Legion Headquarters, 28 rue des Acacias, 75017 Paris. We hope to see as many as possible at the meeting where we will bring you up to date with events and for you to have your say and ask questions of the Officers who will be presenting this meeting.

In this Newsletter you will find the Minutes of the first General Meeting to be held last June. We will have an Agenda for the meeting on the table which you can collect when you sign in for the meeting. The code for the street door/gate is AA58

Look forward to seeing you on 21st February.

Best wishes and Happy New Year to you all.

Janet Warby
Hon. Secretary

THE ROYAL BRITISH LEGION
PARIS BRANCH

GENERAL MEETING

The Paris Branch General Meeting was held on Tuesday 21st June, 2016 at 19h00.

The Chairman, Mr. R. Thorn, welcomed all present and said this was the first such Paris Branch General Meeting in living memory, other than the Annual General Meetings held each November. We are required by London, as laid down in the Membership Handbook, to hold General Meetings at least quarterly. In the past we have informed our members of items of interest in our bi-monthly newsletters.

Members present were : Mesdames Clopet, Corrigan, Hadley, Morris and Warby and Messrs. Bean, Gould, Huggins, Ignatovitch, Plunkett, Scott, Sechet and Yates.

The Chairman asked all present to stand for the Exhortation and Silent Tribute.

Chairman's Report : The Chairman reported he had attended The Royal British Legion Annual Conference in Eastbourne, UK. The Chairman said that our relationship with London was calm and that after last summers fiasco we were back on track in building bridges with London over the Comradeship Project which caused so many problems with our Membership. We were told we were an argumentative branch, but in all honesty we were holding out for the best interest of our Members. At the National Conference many questions were asked by delegates from the floor about the Comradeship Project and why it was a half-baked scheme. There were many questions and answers from which the RBL Management clearly understood that the Membership were not happy with decisions taken without adequately consulting the Members beforehand. The RBL National Chairman said that this was not a perfect project and that people do not like change. The floor informed the Conference that this was an ill conceived and ill executed project. Our Chairman reported that two questions stood out in his mind. They were : i) "was Due Diligence carried out on Novacroft the company given the task to take on our Membership renewals", to which the answer was "NO" and ii) the other question raised was "Who gave authority to move membership data to Novacroft, surely infringing thereby the Date Protection legislation", to which the answer was "this was an usual practice". Remarks from the floor of Conference ranged from "Rubbish to Not Acceptable". The Chairman said that the RBL Management got a hostile reception.

Future Events : The Chairman informed the meeting that our Annual Ceremony of Rekindling the Flamme at the Arc de Triomphe would be held on Thursday 4th August. This year it is the turn of the Canadian Ambassador or his representative to lay the wreath. We await their reply.

The Pedal to Paris would be leaving UK on 1st September and arriving in Paris on 4th September. There will be a wreath laying ceremony at 16h00 at the Arc de Triomphe.

Somme Battlefield Visit : This visit will take place in September (15/16/17th). The group will also take part in a National Ceremony at the Thiepval Memorial organised by TRBL London.

The Annual Coffee Morning to launch the Poppy Appeal will be held at the Ambassador's Residence on Friday 4th November 10h30 – 12h00. Information will be sent out in the Newsletter at the rentree.

The Chairman invited Mr. Peter Huggins to speak to the meeting. Mr. Huggins said he would soon be moving to Germany. He had sorted out some books and had a series of books by Hammerton on World War 2 which contained many documents and records of events during the Second World War in digestible form. Mr. Huggins said he would like to give them to the Legion and said we could either keep the 9 volumes in the Clubhouse or auction them off to raise money for our Funds. The Chairman thanked Mr. Huggins and wished him well in his move to Germany.

The Chairman invited Mr. Philip Sechet to address the meeting. Mr. Sechet said he had addressed the Committee in April outlining his hope of organising a joint venture with TRBL and his Association

Le Souvenir Français of which he is President of the Neuilly sur Seine Branch. Mr. Sechet said the idea was to bring together the British, Commonwealth, U.S., and French Armies to commemorate the end of World War One. V.I.P's from Britain, the Commonwealth and France would be at the event. Mr. Sechet said the Sovenir Français is waiting to get the green light from the French to organise this project, then meetings could begin to decide where best to hold the event. It was intended as a grass-roots veterans' event rather than an official, governmental one. The event would be in the form of a Ceremony and Cocktail. Mr. Sechet said he would inform the Chairman and Committee when he had a suitable answer. The Chairman thanked Mr. Sechet and said he would await any further news of the project.

Hon. Secretary's Report : The Secretary said she had some Poppy Pins to commemorate the 100 years of the Battle of the Somme. There are two types of pin one with just the Poppy and the other with the Poppy and Bleuet. The cost of these was €3 each or €5 for two pins.

Hon. Treasurer's Report : In the absence of the Treasurer, it was reported that the General Fund (Admin) stood at €1,394.72, the Poppy Appeal Account stood at €26,484.82 and the Deposit Account stood at €34,218.82. This report had been proposed by Mr. Plunkett and seconded by Mrs. Hadley. **Carried**

Association de Veterans Brittanique Bar Report : The Chairman asked Mr. Gould if he would like to speak on about the AdVB. Mr. Gould started by explaining that in the UK it was normal in some areas to have an RBL Club with bar. Unfortunately those branches overseas were not allowed to trade in alcohol. So to get around this an Association 1901 had been formed independent of the RBL to run the bar. All RBL Paris Branch members are invited to join. Mr. Gould said he would present his first AGM after our Branch AGM in November.

Welfare Report : Mr. Bean reported that Welfare was very quiet at the moment as there are not many retired British people living in the Paris area. However, we were always ready to assist any Ex-Service Person and or their families who found themselves in need of financial aid.

The Chairman invited Mrs. Hadley to talk about the School Project? Mrs. Hadley informed the meeting that she had attended some Schools/Lycees with British Sections to talk about the Poppies and why we have them. With Mr. Thorn and Mr. Huggins she went to Lycee Pasteur to see their exhibition. With Mr. Thorn, they attended a ceremony at Ranville with that school. Mrs. Hadley said she had a presentation on her computer to show anyone interested in looking at the work. There were 10 schools who had contributed work to the Project and with Messrs. Huggins and Thorn they had judged that Lycee Pasteur were worthy winners of an RBL Trophy. All those pupils who had taken part were presented with a Certificate (160 in total).

There being no further business the meeting was closed at 20h25.